closely inside the Foreign Office. Indeed, this was just the thing that many contemporaries were doing immediately after 1918. For in the aftermath of the First World War public opinion towards the Foreign Office had become highly critical. A common belief developed among strands of the population that it had been the secret machinations of the foreign policy-making elite which had brought Britain into a pointless war. This criticism led to calls for reform of the Foreign Office, both in the way it operated Britain's foreign policy and in the very make-up of its personnel.[46] *The notion of the Foreign Office as an exclusively aristocratic, nepotistic, secretive institution, conducting Britain's foreign affairs with almost unlimited latitude also did much to damage the department's image in the post-war years.*[47] *That in order to support oneself while working for the Diplomatic Service one needed a large independent income compounded the concept of an elitist organisation.*[48] *New Europe produced several articles in 1919 which advocated complete reform of the Foreign Office from the ground up.*[49] *Indeed, even prior to the war, the MacDonnell Royal Commission had recommended wholesale reform, particularly in the recruitment process of the Foreign Office.*[50]

However, many in the Foreign Office resisted these attempts at reform. One observer feared that open competition would allow 'Jews, coloured men and infidels' to enter the foreign service (an example of just the type of bigotry it was hoped the reforms would eliminate).[51] Other more open-minded officials, nevertheless, realised that such changes could improve the Foreign Office by injecting it with new blood.[52] By 1919, then, some of the commission's recommendations were brought in, including abolishing the need for the foreign secretary's nomination for candidates, amalgamating the Diplomatic Service with the Foreign Office, and raising the wages of those officials working abroad. Yet, despite the significant pressure on the Foreign Office from the public, Parliament and from within the government itself, the department changed little.[53] By 1930, the majority of successful candidates for the Foreign Office still had a public school background and graduated from Oxford or Cambridge. Personality, rather than intellectual achievement, was still viewed as the key to a successful career in the foreign service and the selection board continued to look for the same kind of man – and it always was a man – as it had prior to the First World War.[54]